



Final Walkthrough Guide

*Your step-by-step guide to a confident, informed final
walkthrough before closing*

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Faith Nance, REALTOR® — FN Home Group

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Reading Time

~7 minutes

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1 What Is a Final Walkthrough?

The final walkthrough is one of the last steps standing between you and the closing table — here's what it actually is and why it matters.

A final walkthrough is a buyer's opportunity to visit the property one more time before closing to confirm it's in the condition you agreed to purchase it in. This is not a re-inspection. It's a verification step — a chance to see the home with fresh eyes, one final time, before it legally becomes yours.

Unlike your home inspection, which is typically conducted earlier in the process by a licensed professional who examines systems and structures in detail, the final walkthrough is usually done by you (and often your agent) and focuses on confirming that the home matches what you expect: that agreed-upon repairs were completed, that nothing has changed or been damaged since your last visit, and that the property is being left in the condition outlined in your purchase agreement.

Timing matters. Most final walkthroughs happen within 24 to 48 hours before closing, though the exact window can vary depending on your contract and local customs. Scheduling it as close to closing as possible reduces the chance that something changes between your walkthrough and the day you take ownership.

Faith's Tip

Try to schedule your walkthrough for a time when you can move through the home unhurried. Rushing through in ten minutes on your way to sign closing documents makes it easy to miss something that matters.

Did You Know?

The final walkthrough is generally a right outlined in your purchase agreement, not an automatic legal requirement in every transaction. Your contract will specify the timing and any conditions attached to it, so it's worth reviewing that language with your agent.

2 What to Inspect

Use this room-by-room and system-by-system approach to make sure nothing gets overlooked.

Your goal during the walkthrough is threefold: confirm agreed-upon repairs were completed (and, when possible, done well), verify the general condition of the home hasn't declined since your offer was

accepted, and make sure all items included in the sale — fixtures, appliances, and anything else specified in the contract — are actually present and in working order.

It helps to bring a printed copy of your purchase agreement, the inspection report, and any repair addendums so you can compare what you see in person to what was promised in writing. A flashlight, phone charger (to test outlets), and a notepad or your phone's notes app are also useful tools to bring along.

Kitchen

- ☐ All included appliances are present and operate (stove, oven, dishwasher, microwave, refrigerator if included)
- ☐ Sink, garbage disposal, and faucet function properly with no leaks
- ☐ Cabinets and drawers open and close smoothly

Bathrooms

- ☐ Toilets flush properly and don't run continuously
- ☐ Sinks, tubs, and showers drain well with no visible leaks
- ☐ Water pressure and hot water function as expected

HVAC & Utilities

- ☐ Heating and air conditioning turn on and respond to the thermostat
- ☐ Water heater is functioning and no leaks are visible around it
- ☐ All utilities (water, electricity, gas if applicable) are on and working

Interior General Condition

- ☐ Walls, ceilings, and floors show no new damage, stains, or holes
- ☐ Windows and doors open, close, and lock properly
- ☐ Light fixtures and switches work in every room

Exterior

- ☐ Yard, landscaping, and any structures (shed, fence) match the agreed-upon condition
- ☐ No new signs of damage to roof, siding, or driveway
- ☐ Garage door(s) and any remote openers function properly

Faith's Tip

Keep a copy of the listing photos and your inspection report on your phone. Comparing what you see to those references on the spot makes it much easier to spot anything that's changed.

3 Questions to Ask During the Walkthrough

Asking the right questions in the moment can save confusion later.

- Were all the repairs from the inspection agreement completed, and do you have receipts or documentation from the contractors who did the work?
- Has anything changed about the home's condition since we last saw it (weather damage, moving-related damage, new issues)?
- Are all the items listed as included in the sale (appliances, fixtures, window treatments, etc.) still present?
- Have the sellers moved out, and is the home in broom-clean condition as agreed?
- Where are the keys, garage remotes, mailbox keys, and any warranty documents or manuals for appliances and systems?
- Is there anything about the home's operation I should know — like where the water shutoff or breaker panel is located?

Faith's Tip

Ask for repair receipts, not just a verbal confirmation that work was done. Documentation gives you a paper trail and can be useful if a repair issue resurfaces down the road.

4 Common Issues Found at Final Walkthrough

Most walkthroughs go smoothly, but here are some of the more common findings buyers encounter.

- An agreed-upon repair was left incomplete or was done in a way that doesn't match what was promised
- Damage from the moving process, such as scuffed walls, dented doors, or scratched flooring
- Included appliances or fixtures that are missing or have been swapped for lesser items
- Debris, trash, or personal belongings left behind that weren't part of the agreement
- Utilities that have already been shut off, making it difficult to test systems
- Signs of new issues that weren't present during the inspection, such as a fresh leak or a system that no longer powers on

Did You Know?

Many purchase agreements require sellers to leave the home in 'broom-clean' condition, meaning free of trash and debris, but this standard can vary by contract. It's worth confirming exactly what your agreement specifies.

5 What to Do If You Find a Problem

Finding an issue during the walkthrough doesn't have to derail your closing — how you handle it matters most.

If you discover something during the walkthrough that concerns you, the single most important step is to communicate with your agent immediately. Don't wait until you're back home to send a message — call or text from the property so your agent can start documenting the issue and reaching out to the listing agent right away.

Take clear photos and, if helpful, video of whatever you find. Timestamps and detailed notes about what you observed can be valuable if the issue needs to be addressed before closing.

The options available to you from this point depend entirely on your specific purchase agreement, state, and the nature of the issue. In some cases, closing may be delayed briefly to allow for a repair or further discussion. In others, funds may be held in escrow to cover the cost of fixing the problem after closing, or the parties may negotiate a credit. There is no one-size-fits-all resolution, which is exactly why looping in your agent — and, when needed, your real estate attorney — right away is so important.

Faith's Tip

Try to stay calm and factual when documenting an issue. A clear, specific description ('dishwasher does not power on when plugged in and switched at the breaker') is far more useful than a general impression, and it helps everyone move toward a resolution faster.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q. How long does a final walkthrough usually take?

Most final walkthroughs take between 20 and 45 minutes, depending on the size of the home and how thorough you'd like to be. Larger homes or properties with more systems to check may take longer.

Q. Who typically attends the final walkthrough?

Usually the buyer and their agent attend. Sellers and their agent are typically not present, since the home should already be vacated or nearly ready for the buyer's possession, but this can vary by local custom and situation.

Q. What if the sellers haven't moved out yet?

This depends on your contract terms. Some agreements specify a possession date that differs from closing, while others require the home to be vacant by the walkthrough. If you find the sellers still occupying the home unexpectedly, let your agent know immediately so they can clarify the situation.

Q. Can the final walkthrough be done virtually?

In some circumstances, a walkthrough may be conducted virtually via video call, though an in-person walkthrough is generally preferred when possible since it allows you to test systems and inspect details firsthand. Talk with your agent about what makes sense for your situation.

Q. What happens if I can't attend the walkthrough myself?

Many buyers authorize their agent to conduct the walkthrough on their behalf, especially in situations involving distance or scheduling conflicts. Discuss this option with your agent well before closing so a plan can be arranged.

Q. Does the final walkthrough replace the home inspection?

No. The final walkthrough is not a substitute for a professional home inspection. It's a final visual confirmation of the home's condition, not a detailed technical evaluation of its systems and structure.

Final Walkthrough Checklist

☐ Bring purchase agreement, inspection report, and repair addendums

☐ Confirm all agreed-upon repairs were completed

☐ Request receipts or documentation for completed repair work

☐ Test kitchen appliances (stove, oven, dishwasher, microwave)

☐ Check kitchen sink, faucet, and disposal for leaks or issues

☐ Flush toilets and check for running water or leaks in every bathroom

☐ Test hot water and water pressure

☐ Turn on heating and air conditioning to confirm they respond

☐ Check water heater area for leaks or damage

☐ Test all light switches and fixtures throughout the home

☐ Open and close all doors and windows to confirm they work and lock

☐ Inspect walls, ceilings, and floors for new damage

☐ Confirm all included fixtures and items are present

☐ Walk the exterior, yard, and any structures for changes or damage

☐ Test garage door(s) and remote openers

☐ Confirm the home is vacated and left in agreed-upon condition

☐ Collect keys, garage remotes, mailbox keys, and appliance manuals or warranties

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